

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St. Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur

Twice a day collection model

St. Thomas Mount-cum-Pallavaram Cantonment Board introduces a decentralised waste management system thanks to generous support from the Punjab Association



LIFFY THOMAS

Green tri-cycles trundle down the commercial streets in Pallavaram, picking up waste from shops every four hours to be transported to a secondary segregation unit less than a kilometre away. Here 14 workers are engaged in sorting recyclables into different categories, and the biodegradable waste is separated for composting.

For the last one week, shops in this busy neighbourhood, there are 650 as per data, are getting used to an attendance system where they are marked based on a few criteria including if they handed over segregated waste.

St. Thomas Mount-cum-Pallavaram Cantonment Board has engaged the service of Vellore-based C. Srinivasan to adopt the Solid and



A tricycle doing the rounds of commercial streets in Pallavaram; and during the inauguration of SLRM project.

Liquid Resource Management (SLRM) concept to strengthen the waste collection and segregation system in the neighbourhood that extends from Le Royal Meridian Hotel to the Pallavaram bus stop.

Dubbed the "Vellore Model" or the SLRM Project,

here greater emphasis is laid on dispatching waste within 12 hours so that it can be converted into a resource. The collection interval increases depending on the nature of waste generated and the location. For hotels, restaurants, marriage halls, road side vendors, the workers are

Punjab Association forays into a new segment

Punjab Association, which runs five schools and a college in Chennai, has stepped into a new segment - environment management by sponsoring the SLRM project in the Cantonment area. The tricycles used for waste collection, red and green buckets and the infrastructure for decentralised management of waste has all been funded by the Punjab Association. Vikram Aggarwal, president, Punjab Association, says a study was conducted by a consultant that identified the Cantonment area as needing a higher education institute. "We have started an arts and science college from this academic year in Cantonment and thought it was good to partner for a cleaner and sustainable neighbourhood," says Vikram. Dr Vikram Aggarwal Adarsh College of Arts and Science offers undergraduate programmes across arts, science and commerce streams. "Like the other institutions under our banner, the college will offer holistic education and cater to student from less-privileged communities," says Vikram.

required to collect the waste every six hours; bulk generators such as markets every four hours; and for shops selling non-vegetarian items three hours is the duration.

"When collected garbage is bundled in black plastic covers without aeration, anaerobic decomposition occurs leading to bad odours. In our model, waste collection is done twice a day to ensure collected inorganic waste is processed and packed ready for sale and organic waste is spread in aerobic compost beds or tanks, after mixing with cow dung slurry as a bacterial inoculum," says C. Srinivasan, pro-

ject director and consultant, Solid and Liquid Resource Management, who first implemented the model in Vellore.

Involving women from self-help groups from in and around the neighbourhood is another highlight of this model which ensures a sense of ownership, and also ticks one of the key SDG (Sustainable Development Goals) boxes.

Srinivasan, a resource person for SLRM Project of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, says under this decentralised model of managing resources they ensure no waste is sent to dumping grounds, and revenue is generated through decentralised segregation, aerobic composting and recycling. All this reduces transportation cost and overflow of waste at dumping sites.

The SLRM model was launched as a pilot six months ago at RWA SOL Army Married Accommodation now to be extended to other residential areas. From

the households, waste is picked twice a day (8 a.m. to 9 and 4 p.m. to 5 p.m.).

"We collect the materials before they start decomposing so workers do not have a reason to complain. That is why we call it resource management," says Srinivasan.

Vinod Vikneswaran A., Indian Defence Estates Service, Chief Executive Officer, St. Thomas Mount-cum-Pallavaram Cantonment Board, says the Board does not work either with the Greater Chennai Corporation or the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation to manage its waste. "We were following a door-to-door collection mechanism but disposal was a challenge. Non-biodegradable waste was not being processed. With SLRM, we will be sending non-biodegradable waste to industries to be used as raw materials," says

Vinod, adding that 13,500 household come under the network.



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Tambaram Corporation's park below the MIT flyover on the eastern side of Chromepet, which was opened to the public in February; and the vacant space below the MIT flyover on the western side of Chromepet, where residents want a park developed. PHOTOS: T. ARVIND

T. ARVIND

Residents of New Colony and other neighbourhoods on the western side of Chromepet have urged the Tambaram Corporation to develop parks and recreational spaces. They say the area has been overlooked while similar facilities have come up on the eastern side of the suburb.

Senior citizens, children and youth say the western neighbourhoods lack adequate open spaces for recreation despite the availability of vacant land and Open Space Reservation (OSR) sites.

The Tambaram Corporation recently developed a park with children's play equipment beneath the Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam Radial Road bridge, popularly known as the Ponds Bridge. Another park, with facilities including a gym and children's play area, was opened beneath the MIT

West Chromepet needs more lung spaces

Residents cite disparity in recreational facilities between eastern and western neighbourhoods; Corporation promises inspection

flyover near Chitlapakkam Main Road-R.P. Road junction in February this year. Both have been well received by residents.

Demand for a similar facility

Senior social activist V. Santhanam said residents of western Chromepet welcomed the civic improvements on the eastern side but felt that recreational amenities had not been distributed equitably.

He pointed to a vacant stretch beneath the MIT flyover in GST Road, along the service road op-

posite the Vodafone office, as a suitable location for developing a park similar to the one beneath the Ponds Bridge.

A visit to the site found the area overgrown with shrubs and partly occupied by parked vehicles from nearby commercial establishments. According to local residents, several motorists leave their vehicles there for days, while a few automobile workshops use portions of the service road to dump scrap vehicles, affecting free movement and turning the

vacant land into an informal garage.

"The Corporation can clear the encroachments and develop the space into a park with walking paths and seating facilities. It would provide much-needed relief to senior citizens and youngsters looking for a place to read or spend their leisure time," Santhanam said.

"I often have to wait a long time for outstation buses on weekends. A park nearby would be an ideal place to spend the time," said Jaya-

seelen, a youth from New Colony who frequently travels to his native place on weekends.

OSR land identified

Residents have also urged the Corporation to identify land earmarked under the Open Space Reservation (OSR) provisions in CLC Works Road, where several private hospitals and commercial establishments function.

"Despite repeated representations, no inspection has been carried out to identify OSR land for developing parks," Santhanam said.

Tambaram Corporation Commissioner S. Balachandran said he would instruct officials to inspect the vacant land beneath the MIT flyover on the western side of Chromepet. He also assured residents that steps would be taken to examine the feasibility of developing the site into a public recreational space.

Redeveloped park in Rajakilpakkam loses green cover

Residents are upset that amenities such as a yoga hall and provisions for dispensing drinking water were removed

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Members of the Environment Awareness and Protection Association (EAPA) were shocked to see the condition of Annai Anjugam Park in Rajakilpakkam when they visited the place on June 27 for the monthly environment awareness session.

Reopened after three-and-a-half years to facilitate redevelopment work, the park today features a spacious skating rink and a badminton court.

The trees in the park have been felled. Residents say the park has lost its green cover drastically to facilitate these new amenities. The park was closed for constructing a stormwater drain network at Vallal Yusuf Nagar in Selaiyur. The network connects Sembakkam Lake via the park at Maruthi Nagar and along Church



The badminton court and the skating rink at the park, and (right) the park facade used to have bamboo trees, now only a few are to be found. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Street in Mahalakshmi Nagar.

The park was renovated at a cost of more than ₹ 52 lakhs and was thrown open to the public in February.

"The plants at the garden areas along Church Street are missing and dumped with sand, stones and trash," says V. Seetha-

raman, secretary, Federation of Rajakilpakkam Residents' Welfare Associations and a member of EAPA.

More needed

Prior to the redevelopment of the park, there was a functional fountain, a meditation and a yoga hall,

toilets and drinking water facilities. Except for the toilets, all are missing now. J. Poornima, a senior citizen and a retired school teacher, says, "More play and open gym equipment should have been provided."

"The park has lost its charm. Earlier, it was a cool place with a

lot of plants. There is a considerable decrease in visitors to the park," says K. Meenakshi Krishnaswamy.

R. Bhavani Rajendran, a visitor, says, "As the yoga hall has been removed, a section of visitors meditate and do yoga on the walking path, which disturbs walkers. Along Maruthi Nagar Main Road, the garden waste should be composted, but it is burnt instead."

The Tambaram City Municipal Corporation should increase the greenery. At strategic locations, dustbins should be placed. Seats of the merry-go-round are rusted, and cracks could be spotted, residents pointed out.

"We have decided to send a petition to C. Joseph Vijay, Chief Minister, and meet the Commissioner of the Tambaram Corporation to increase the greenery and provide more play equipment," adds Seetharaman.

READERS WRITE



The condition of the pavement slabs along Sixth Main Road and 43rd Street in Nanganallur. Photo: Special ArrangementTHE HINDU

Complete pending work on walkway in Nanganallur

N. SRIRAM

When work on laying a walkway on Sixth Main Road in Nanganallur commenced months ago, a section near the Independence Day Park was left behind. The work has to be taken up for the magnitude of traffic on the stretch during rush hour.

Along Fifth Main Road and Sixth Main Road, vehicles are parked on the pavement forcing pedestrians to walk on the carriageway. Likewise, near a toilet, veh-

icles are parked.

As there are no medians, MTC bus drivers from Fourth Main Road to proceed on Fifth Main Road go in the wrong direction, posing a risk to pedestrians.

Outside the park, pavement slabs are missing or broken. Along 43rd Street, the slabs are broken, placed on one another and cannot be negotiated. Only for a few meters, pedestrians can access the walkway.

The walkway is taken over by vehicles, construction materials and commercial establishments,

alongside vehicular parking forcing pedestrians to share space with motorists.

A cement walkway with fences and bollards outside the homes and commercial establishments should be put up. The Alandur zone should ensure there are no wide gaps between the bollards. As lighting is inadequate at the pavement area, the pedestrians negotiating through the walkway can suffer from sprain, given the walkway condition.

N. Sriram is a resident of Nanganallur

Provide full address of relocated post office

N K RAJA

The post office in Suriya Nagar, Medavakkam, was relocated more than three weeks ago, but there was no announcement in newspapers.

The post office has been relocated to Pushpa Nagar, and patrons learned of the change after seeing a board announcing the shift at the old location. But the

full address of the new location is not given on the board.

The office has been shifted behind a two-wheeler showroom in the locality, forcing patrons to search hard for it in the absence of a signboard.

N K Raja is a social activist and president of Nesamani Nagar Residents' Welfare Association, Perumbakkam

You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number



Stray cattle, a risk to vehicle users in Selaiyur

J MOSES

The increasing number of stray cattle on Agaramthen Road and Tambaram Eastern Bypass Road in Selaiyur and Tiruvanchery poses a threat to public safety.

Although the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation has imposed a ban on cattle roaming on public roads, it appears ineffective.

The traffic wing of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate, in joint efforts with the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, needs to act on this to ensure public safety.

The presence of cattle on busy highways poses a significant risk to two-and-four-wheelers, and pedestrians, often leading to accidents and even loss of lives. In recent times, several road accidents have been reported due to stray cattle wandering onto these roads.



The Tambaram Corporation must strictly enforce its regulations by identifying owners, imposing substantial penalties for violations,

and relocating the cattle to goshas.

J. Moses is a resident of Chromepet

Speed breaker needed at intersection in Nanganallur

D. VISWANATHAN

At the intersection of 16th Street and Third Main Road in Nanganallur, there is a need for speed breakers.

From 16th Street, people proceeding towards Third Main Road and vice versa often meet with accidents as motorists negotiate at high speeds.

Speed breakers should be laid at the junction to prevent accidents.

D Viswanathan is a resident of Nanganallur



'Construct walls along tracks'

S. LOGARANI

The Southern Railway should construct walls or put up fences around the tracks along GST Road in New Perungalathur and Otteri regions.

There are five openings between Perungalathur and Vandalur railway stations.

The pedestrians cross the tracks and come through Krishna Street to go to Sarojini Street, Krishna Street, Gandhi Road, Erikarai Salai and Lal Bahadur Shastri Street.

A man crosses the tracks between Vandalur and Perungalathur railway stations.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The pedestrians should come through GST Road, Kamarajar Salai and Arunagiri Nathar Street in New Perungalathur.

Through NGO Colony, a section of Cheran Street in RMK Nagar, Nehru Nagar Main Road, Nehru High Road, RMK Nagar, Indira Gandhi Road, and Nehru Street, MRK Nagar.

Years ago, when walls were constructed along GST Road, abutting the tracks, the portions were left out for reasons unknown. Today, the portions have become a walkway for pedestrians, who have to negotiate through uneven, stoned and unhygienic surfaces.

This is a risky affair and pedestrians are at risk of being knocked down and this should be curbed at the earliest by putting up fences or constructing walls.

S. Logarani is a resident of Otteri

'Introduce small buses in Madambakkam'

A.V. NARAYANAN

Mappedu is a fast-developing suburb connecting Camp Road with a 200-foot road; it is well served by bus connectivity to the Tambaram railway station. However, on the eastern side, Madambakkam, a residential area, is not connected to Mappedu by any public transport via Agaramthen Main Road.

There is a need to ply small buses via Padmavathy Nagar to the Madambakkam Main Road up to Dhe-nupureeswarar Temple. As this route is well-populated and has wide roads, small buses would be well patronised. The Metropolitan Transport Corporation should study this at the earliest.

A. V. Narayanan is a resident of Thiruvanchery

Earthen resolve

In Chennai, an enterprise focussed on making curd pots has completed its golden jubilee due to a man who would not give up. This enterprise is as small as it gets; it has two members on its rolls, he and his wife



A whirlwind tour of the curd pot making unit at Royapettah; the people in the images are K. Manohar and M. Bhuvaneshwari.

PHOTOS: R. RAGU

drying the pots and firing them. He makes these pots with clay sourced from Red Hills. Every day, he manages to make 200-300 pots; after he has racked up around 2,000 pots, he initiates the firing process.

He maintains an inventory of 4000 pots at any point in time. Though not extremely keen on retailing, he does not shy away from it either. The pots are priced in the range of ₹8 to ₹10 each. He is content servicing that one bulk order, one that keeps him busy.

The address he operates from was apparently originally called Royapettah-Kosapet for its association with the making of clay pots and lamps. It was subsequently changed to Maavadi Vinayagar Koil Street. His workspace comes at a rent of ₹5000 per month; and the demand for firewood having gone up partly during the time there was a gripping fear of LPG shortage and not climbing down, his pot-making costs have gone up.

When he fires a batch of pots, he faces protest from neighbours on account of the smoke the process generates. To avoid friction with the neighbours, he restricts pot-firing to one day in a week, that too on a week day, so that when the process takes place, most residents are away, at their workplaces, schools and colleges. Manohar can be reached at 9790843188

Every day, he manages to make 200-300 pots; after he has racked up around 2,000 pots, he initiates the firing process

A LONG INNINGS

is a column about enterprises in Chennai that have successfully dodged the curveballs of time often with plain grit and nothing else



R. RAGU

A resident of Maavadi Vinayagar Koil Street at Balaji Nagar in Royapettah, K. Manohar has been in the business of making small curd pots (*dahi handi*). Having seen 65 summers, Manohar has witnessed the vicissitudes of time, as has his business alongside him, which is obviously younger than him but not significantly. The business keeps “firing”, showing no signs of ageing; it is 50 years old.

There are challenges, but Manohar has soldiered on, watching his

business outlive even star hotels that once placed huge orders with him but have since slipped into oblivion.

As things stand, he supplies these pots to one star hotel in Chennai, the enterprise attracted to his creations for the novelty they bring to the table.

He functions with a two-member team, that is, if one counts him in. The only other team member is also his partner for life, M. Bhuvaneshwari his wife: talk about family-run business!

She chips in by helping him with preparations for processes such as

At the Oncology Kitchen at ICH, Egmore; and (below) the caretaker of a child undergoing treatment at ICH registering as part of the process to take food from the Oncology Kitchen to the child.



A worry taken off their plate

Oncology Kitchen at the Institute of Child Health and Hospital for Children in Egmore meets the huge nutritional needs of children undergoing cancer treatment. And the fact that the bill of fare comes free is a huge relief to their parents

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Malnutrition is cancer's wingman with a cruiser-ready shotgun. Cancer is formidable enough without this companion-in-arms by its side; and when the two team up, a two-front war is a necessity. At the government-run Institute of Child Health and Hospital for Children (ICH) in Egmore, oncologists and social workers are engaged in such a war, the former treating the children at the cancer ward and the latter, treating them to eats, as nourishing as they are tasty, at a unique kitchen.

It is called "Oncology Kitchen", clearly the rarest of rare lexical pairs. But this one enjoys easy familiarity with the tongues of its beneficiaries (at any given time around 50 children undergoing cancer treatment at ICH as well as a few children being treated for thalassemia) because from Monday to Saturday, between 10 a.m. and 11 a.m., the aroma of health food tas-

tily done wafts out of this kitchen and heads to the beds at the cancer ward. The caretaker of a child registers and takes the food to the ward. Children who are not weak might tag along with their caretakers, and following registration, have the food in the kitchen.

G.V. Williams, founder of the voluntary organisation Myrtle Social Welfare Network, which runs the Oncology Kitchen at ICH, notes this kitchen is hardly an add-on service, but one integral to cancer treatment which often causes severe weight loss and declining blood counts and ups nutritional demands significantly. Oncology Kitchen programme coordinator Tryphosa Mavis recalls the story of Devayani (name changed), a child diagnosed with blood cancer and who following treatment, was reduced to skin

COLLECTIVE KINDNESS
is a column about efforts by voluntary agencies and individual volunteers shoring up strikingly direct and noticeable initiatives by government agencies to serve the underprivileged sections of society



and bones. With proper nutrition and care from the Oncology Kitchen, she improved, gaining the necessary weight and showing adequately increased blood levels. Today, she visits the hospital only for monthly follow-ups, and has become an icon of hope for parents whose children are facing similar weight loss. Seeing Devayani, they know their child

too need not stay emaciated on account of cancer treatment.

The kitchen offers another balm to parents; in fact a cure, ridding them of the anxiety of having to provide their children up against cancer with nutritious food; it takes that worry off their plate.

Everything on the bill of fare at the Oncology Kitchen is free of cost. It was with this dual aim the Oncology Kitchen was launched at ICH on April 18, 2024, says Wil-

liams.

He rattles off the usual contents of the menu: rice porridge, health mix, cut fruits, milk, boiled eggs and sprouts. In addition, the kitchen offers customised meals. He elaborates that some children require to be on a specialised diet plan based on their condition and treatment and the preparation in the kitchen follows the food prescriptions written out by the oncologist. The kitchen serves 300 to 360 meals every week, with the total weekly cost ranging between ₹40,000 and ₹50,000. Among Myrtle's plans for the future is increasing the offering to three meals a day.

A close encounter

The inspiration to start Oncology Kitchen dates back to 2015, when Williams saw his friend lose his daughter to cancer; the girl was struck in the prime of her life, being just 20 years old at the time of death. Before her death, she wished that no child suffering from cancer should be left uncared for; even when facing the inevitable, her voice only reflected compassion, recalls Williams.

The kitchen is one of the outcomes of a memorandum of understanding Myrtle Social Welfare Network signed with ICH to support the children undergoing cancer treatment at the hospital and their parents in various ways. Besides seeking to keep these children in good health through the Oncology Kitchen, the voluntary organisation keeps them in good cheer through activities (for a sense of what they do at ICH), check out their Insta page @myrtle_social_welfare_network.

Notable ways in which secondary support shows up include: one, recognising that siblings are often neglected during a medical crisis, it provides educational support for them. It further conducts monthly parent support meetings where families share experiences, seek guidance and support one another through difficult times, Williams notes.

Among the assurances made to the hospital about the Oncology Kitchen is a commitment to maintaining hygiene and sanitation standards. Overseen by a manager and a supervisor, the kitchen comes with the assurance of FSSAI certification, says Williams.

Williams notes that when the idea of a kitchen of this stripe was up in the air, the hospital authorities and parents gave it a double thumbs up, displaying an unbiased mind. He adds that the government has definitely been benevolent with their constant support.

The NGO meets the expenditure with donations from individuals and organisations. People can also sponsor meals for the children undergoing treatment.

For details about the Oncology Kitchen, contact Myrtle Social Welfare Network at 9840096022.

The *dry waste* collection drive near you



Ashwini H. Pandit at her driveway at Vasudeva Nagar in Thiruvannmiyur

Meet three Chennai residents who have brought the healthy practice of squirrelling away dry discards for the recycler to their neighbourhood and also made it regular. These initiatives are having a buy-in from their neighbours

The initiative, coordinated through the apartment's WhatsApp groups, has also nudged residents towards more mindful disposal practices. Instead of throwing away batteries, keyboards or tube lights, many now message Sreevidhya to ask where they can be responsibly discarded. To Sreevidhya, that change in behaviour is more significant than the volume of waste collected. She believes the foundation for sustainable living must be laid early. "Children should be educated, not just at school, but at home too so they know what can be recycled and why it should never end up as mixed waste," she says.

For details, email sreevidhyaashok03@gmail.com

Make it hyperlocal if you can

G. Saranya is guided by a simple but effective principle: waste should not have to travel farther than the people willing to recycle it. And this belief has led her to facilitate a dry waste collection drive within her sprawling residential community in Pallikaranai.

Having regularly dropped off old clothes, footwear and other household discards at citizen-led collection drives while accompanying her mother for medical appointments, Saranya realised that her own community lacked the avenue for responsible disposal of items such as worn-out school uniforms, tattered clothes, toys and footwear.

Rather than spearheading the initiative herself, Saranya chose to play the role of a facilitator. Recognising the scale of her community, home to more than 2,000 families, she reached out to residents' association members and introduced them to organisers already conducting collection drives across Chennai.

The proposal is now taking shape, with discussions under way to organise a dedicated collection drive within the community. Saranya hopes it will evolve into a regular, neighbourhood-level effort, making responsible disposal as convenient as taking out the household waste. "People do not have time to go somewhere and drop these things. If it is a monthly drive, they will start collecting everything," she says

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

A drive in the driveway

Ashwini H. Pandit's driveway at Vasudeva Nagar in Thiruvannmiyur makes room for unlikely occupants, one Saturday every month: washed milk covers, biscuit wrappers, Tetra Paks, cartons, old clothes and discarded electronics items. They are deposited in the space by neighbours, around 15 of them, who share Ashwini's faith in recycling dry waste.

For a year and half now, Ashwini runs this citizens-led dry waste collection drive. "Garbage all over the city and dirty roads triggered me," she says. "I feel anything can be used. It has a life and should not go into the bin."

The collected waste is passed on to organisations that further segregate it before sending it to recyclers.

For Ashwini, the issue is less about the absence of collection systems and more about everyday habits. "Segregation is the key," she notes. "If everything is mixed, nobody would be willing to do it." She hopes more households will begin with small changes like washing and drying recyclable waste, composting kitchen scraps and carrying reusable bags. "We are not even one percent there yet. We have a

long way to go," says Ashwini.

Residents in and around Thiruvannmiyur can drop off their segregated dry waste at Ashwini's monthly collection drive. For details, call 96633 40341

The power of local engagement

Sreevidhya Ashok, a resident of Vijayanagar in Velachery learnt the ropes of community waste man-

agement with Residents of Kasturbanagar Association (ROKA) volunteering with it for six years, being particularly engaged with its city-wide collection drives. And one day, she decided it was essential to bring the initiative closer, make dry waste collection a monthly, local exercise.

Since last month, Sreevidhya has been hosting a collection every

last Saturday. "People were eagerly waiting for the yearly drive, but they found it difficult to store recyclables for so long," she said. "So we thought, why not conduct it every month?"

The response to the first drive validated the move: nearly 300 kg of material was collected, with reusable items accounting for nearly 70% of the collection.

Other efforts

*At Raja Street, Mandaveli, a fortnightly dry waste collection drive is conducted in collaboration with Kabadiwalla Connect; it takes place on a Saturday. For details about nearby drop-off points, call 99400 56069

*Founder of Zero Waste Initiatives at Boutique Bougainvillea in Velachery, Sherin Joseph conducts a monthly waste collection drive every fourth Sunday (2 to 5 p.m.) since January 2025. For details, call 98410 75367

* At RK Nagara in Mandaveli, a community-led waste collection initiative has been running for the past 7-8 years, organised in collaboration with recycling partners. It is held once every 4-5 months. For details, call 70108 48668

* Citizen-led waste management initiatives in MRC Nagar have been active since 2013, dry waste collection drives are conducted once or twice a year, with designated building-level collection points like gyms and common rooms used for drop-offs. For details, call 96000 47586



The shed at Valmiki Nagar to collect dry waste

* A shed installed in Valmiki Nagar nearly seven years ago has been repurposed as a community drop-off point since the first waste collection drive was organised in August 2021. For the past two years, collection drives have been held once every three months, from 11 a.m. to 5 p.m. For details, call 98402 04192

A message for a drug-free society



An anti-drug awareness rally was conducted by the staff and students of S.I.V.E.T College in Gowrivakkam. The rally was flagged off by assistant commissioner of police, Selaiyur and other police personnel. R. Saravanan, dean; J. Renugadevi, principal (in-charge); NSS and anti-drug awareness coordinators M. Balu and K. Parthiban participated. More than 400 students took part in the rally that commenced from the college campus and proceeded to Kamarajapuram bus stand, passing through major roads in the locality. Students carried placards displaying anti-drug messages, raised awareness slogans and presented a street play.

Training programme on media drone operations

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu is conducting a training programme on media drone operations from July 6 to 8 at the institute's premises at SIDCO Industrial Estate in Guindy. Time: From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m.

According to a press release, the workshop focuses on drone

technology, drone cinematography techniques, aerial photography, FPV (First-Person View) cinematography, and safety regulations under Director General of Civil Aviation.

Media drone pilots have career opportunities in industries and sectors such as: film and television, news and media, social media, tourism and hospitality, advertising and marketing, fire

and rescue operations, police and military surveillance, and forest & wildlife.

Those aged 18 and above and with a minimum qualification of class 10 can take part. Accommodation facility is available at affordable price but based on a first-come, first-served basis.

For details, call 8668100181 / 9360221280.

Academician honoured for 50 years of social service

Naesey' J. Ramachandran, founder of Naesey Charitable Trust and chancellor of AMET University, was recently honoured for completing 50 years in social service.

Rajesh Ramachandran, president of AMET University, delivered the welcome address and launched a documentary chronicling the academician's decades of social service, youth empowerment, employment generation, and community development.

The programme saw eminent personalities from public life, academia, and politics who felicitated Ramachandran for his contributions.

Parveen Sultana, an orator, lauded Ramachandran's lifelong commitment to social service and

his sustained efforts to empower youth, create livelihood opportunities, and establish institutions that have benefited society across diverse sectors.

J.C.D. Prabhakar, Speaker, Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, described Ramachandran as a humanitarian who dedicated himself to serving society even before achieving personal success.

Su. Thirunavukkarasar, former Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president, recalled his long association with Ramachandran and traced his inspiring journey from Valudavur village in Villupuram district to becoming an internationally recognized educationist.

"His initiatives have benefited nearly 2.5 lakh families, impacting close to one million people."



J.C.D. Prabhakar, Speaker, Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, honouring J. Ramachandran at the felicitation ceremony. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Students go on a twisting spree



Chettinad Vidyashram observed International Yoga Day on the theme 'Sarvam Yoga Mayam' during the morning assembly on June 20. Sudama Vipra Das, vice president of ISKCON, graced the event.

S. Amudha Lakshmi, principal, emphasised the role of yoga in nurturing discipline, focus and physical fitness.

More than 100 students presented a

mass demonstration of various asanas and breathing exercises at the event conducted by the Yoga department.

A few solo performers also demonstrated advanced asanas, highlighting their flexibility, focus, and confidence, said a release.

Vipra Das discussed the significance of yoga and encouraged students to embrace it as a lifelong practice to maintain a healthy, balanced life.

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Lakeside snack stall bolstered by an indomitable spirit



Unmindful of their locomotor disabilities, couple Prabhu L. and Priya Prabhu have made bold business moves and their efforts have paid off, going by the patronage they enjoy in Madipakkam

LIFFY THOMAS

Visitors to Madipakkam Lake View Road are so accustomed to the sight of Prabhu L. and Priya Prabhu sitting along the lake front with their snack varieties spread on the pavement that their absence even for a day would trigger a chain of enquiries.

For the last seven years, almost every day from 4.30 p.m. to 8.30 p.m., this couple, both persons



At Lake View Road in Madipakkam, the couple open the shop every evening.

with locomotor disabilities, run their modest business. And they are rich from having accumulated

loyal customers.

Prabhu and Priya's story is one of supporting each other. Prabhu

had been a telephone operator in Dharmapuri and held other jobs in metros before quitting from Suth-

erland Global Services in Chennai to help Priya become a homepreneur.

"What after me?" was a question haunting me for long and I wanted to empower Priya to do something that lay within her abilities. She had only studied till Class X and needed someone to back her fully," says Prabhu, who has a post-graduate degree in computer applications.

In 2007, they brought home an oil-extracting machine and started selling cold pressed oil. When summer set in they started making avakai pickles and slowly expanded to sell apalams, vadams and other snacks.

They started by selling savouries outside temples in Madipakkam, each day dedicated to one area. Later, they expanded the scope of their business by choosing Lake View Road and it turned out to be tasmalamic to them. Many walkers started taking note of the way they went about doing their business to help them.

TRV Rajan of Techcom Solutions helped him start the venture. A number of people have given the couple stalls at exhibitions free of cost including V. R. Muralidharan, president of TAMBRAS Velachery; and Keerthi Vasani Iyer from Agraharam Group.

The couple are also grateful for the support received from Sumathi Raghuraman, Radha Sethuraman, Brindha Subbarao and Vijayalakshmi Sreeram.

"We started Madipakkam Rao Home Foods with an initial investment of ₹ 10,000 and we have now come a long way with the support of many well wishers," says Prabhu, grateful to his school group for the help extended to them.

Priya too is happy to have learnt the ropes of running a business and being financially independent. She says, "During the pandemic we did struggle a lot. My son would help us in delivering items sought by customers at their doorsteps."

Contact Prabhu at 9500064260

New road provides access to gated community



Navin's has opened a new 60-ft-wide entry road connecting Navin's Starwood Towers with the neighbouring Me-

davakkam community.

As part of its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives, the company aims to improve accessi-

bility, strengthen local connectivity, and deliver long-term benefits for residents and the wider neighbourhood, said a release.

The road opening ceremony was graced by V. Jeyachandran, president of Medavakkam Panchayat; Kalyanaraman, Chief Operating Officer; Prabhakar, Vice President - Technical; and Giridharan, General Manager - Purchase, all from Navin's, along with members of the SWT Associations.

The newly-laid road is expected to ease movement for residents while enhancing connectivity between Navin's Starwood Towers and surrounding areas, contributing to the locality's overall growth, added the release.

Free textbooks for college students

RYA Book Bank starts giving away application forms for its annual book distribution programme

Rajasthan Youth Association (RYA) Book Bank has started giving away application forms for its free textbooks scheme.

Students seeking books for B.Com, B.Com CS, BBM, BBA, B.Com CA, B.Com ISM, B.Sc Mathematics, BCA, B.Sc Computer Science can apply. Engineering students can opt from the second years of BE courses.

The free application form can also be collected from the RYA office at No.4, Atkinson Palace, Jothi Venkatachalam Road, behind Office of Commissioner of Police,



Vepery; between 10.30 a.m. and 5.30 p.m. The form can also be downloaded online from www.ryabookbank.com.

Last date to apply is July 20.

For details, call 044-25610978 / Dinesh at 98402 03362